DIY CONCRETE

DRESS PLANTER

Lace fabric · Concrete draping · Stunning garden sculpture

Step-by-Step Professional Guide

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ABOUT THIS PROJECT

This guide shows you how to create a breathtaking concrete dress planter — one of the most shared DIY garden projects on social media. The technique is simpler than it looks: a lace fabric is draped over a terracotta pot mold, coated with a cement slurry, and left to cure. The lace transfers its intricate floral pattern into the concrete surface permanently. Once cured, the fabric is removed (or left in), the pot is flipped, and you have a stunning dress-shaped planter with a detailed lace texture that looks like it costs hundreds. Plant with trailing flowers for maximum drama.

Difficulty	Beginner
Time	2 hours active + 48h cure
Cost	$15–$25
Result	1 large dress planter
Durability	Weather-resistant, permanent

MATERIALS & TOOLS

ITEM	QTY	NOTES
Large lace fabric (skirt)	1 piece	80–100 cm diameter; bridal/curtain lace works best
Corset/bodice fabric (lace)	1 piece	For the upper body section of the dress
Portland cement or craft cement	2–3 kg	Fine grain for best lace detail transfer
Water	As needed	Mix to thick paint consistency — not too runny
Large terracotta pot (mold)	1	20–25 cm diameter; inverted as the dress form
Mixing bucket & brush	1 set	Wide brush for applying cement slurry
Plastic wrap or bag	1 roll	Wrap the pot before draping — aids removal
Wire or armature (optional)	Small qty	To shape the bodice section if needed
Concrete sealer	1 can	Matte exterior sealer — protects lace detail
Potting mix & drainage gravel	As needed	To fill finished planter for planting
Safety gloves	1 pair	Cement is alkaline — protect hands

STEP-BY-STEP PROCESS

01 CHOOSE & PREPARE YOUR FABRIC

Selecting the lace fabric for the dress

Choose a lace fabric with a clearly defined floral or geometric pattern — the more open the weave, the better the concrete detail. Bridal lace, curtain lace, or tablecloth lace all work beautifully. Cut the skirt piece into a large circle (80–100 cm diameter) and a smaller bodice piece. Soak both pieces in water until fully saturated — this helps the cement slurry penetrate the fibres.

★ PRO TIP The more detailed the lace pattern, the more stunning the finished p stretchy fabrics — they distort under the weight of wet cement.

02 PREPARE THE MOLD

Wrapping the terracotta pot in plastic before draping

Invert a large terracotta pot on a stable surface — this is your dress form. Wrap the entire pot in plastic wrap or cling film — this prevents the cement from bonding to the pot and makes removal easy after curing. The pot rim becomes the waist of the dress; the base becomes the top opening for planting.

★ PRO TIP Use a pot with a slightly tapered shape rather than straight sides — natural dress silhouette when the fabric drapes over it.

03 MIX THE CEMENT SLURRY

Mixing cement to a thick paint-like consistency

Mix Portland cement (or a fine craft cement) with water to a thick paint consistency — similar to thick yogurt or heavy cream. It should coat a brush and drip slowly, not run. Too thin = cement falls off the fabric before curing. Too thick = clogs the lace pattern. Mix only what you can use in 20–30 minutes.

★ PRO TIP Add a small amount of PVA glue (1 tablespoon per litre of water) to dramatically improves adhesion to the fabric fibres and reduces cra

04 APPLY CEMENT TO THE SKIRT

Brushing cement slurry onto the draped lace fabric

Lay the saturated lace skirt flat and brush cement slurry onto one side generously — ensuring it penetrates through the weave. Then drape the coated side down over the inverted pot, adjusting the folds and pleats for a natural dress silhouette. Apply another coat of slurry over the top surface, working the cement into all the lace detail.

★ PRO TIP Work quickly — once the cement starts to set (15–20 min), you can without cracking the surface.

05 SHAPE & FORM THE BODICE

Shaping the bodice section on top of the skirt

Place the smaller bodice piece over the top of the pot (where the dress waist is). Shape it to suggest a corseted bodice — pinch, fold and tuck the fabric to create structure. Apply cement slurry to this section, working it into the lace detail. Use your fingers to define any seam lines, boning details or bustline shape.

★ PRO TIP If the bodice fabric won't hold its shape, support it with crumpled alu pieces of wire while the cement begins to set.

06 CURE UNDISTURBED 48 HOURS

The cement-coated dress curing on the pot mold

Once shaped, leave the entire piece completely undisturbed for 24–48 hours. Mist lightly with water every few hours during the first day to slow the cure in hot weather — rapid drying causes cracking. Cover loosely with plastic if it's very sunny or windy. The cement will change from dark grey to a lighter stone colour as it cures.

★ PRO TIP Don't rush the cure. The lace detail is most vulnerable in the first 12 movement at this stage causes micro-cracks in the surface.

07 REMOVE THE MOLD

Carefully removing the terracotta pot from the cured dress

Once fully cured, carefully lift the pot out of the dress form. The plastic wrap should allow clean separation. If there is any resistance, gently twist the pot rather than pulling straight. The lace fabric can be left inside (it becomes part of the structure) or carefully peeled away — leaving it in adds internal reinforcement.

★ PRO TIP If the lace is pulling away with it, stop and cut the fabric free with sci
risking cracking the concrete.

08 SEAL & PLANT

Finished concrete dress planter with flowers in the garden

Apply 2 coats of matte exterior concrete sealer to all surfaces, allowing 4 hours between coats. This protects the delicate lace texture from frost, UV and rain. Add drainage gravel to the base of the opening, then potting mix. Plant with trailing flowers — petunias, lobelia, or ivy — so they cascade over the sides of the dress. Place in the garden at golden hour and photograph immediately.

★ PRO TIP Pink or white trailing flowers cascading over the dress silhouette at
that goes viral. Position the planter with the best-detail side facing th

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	SOLUTION
Cement falls off fabric before curing	Slurry too thin; fabric not saturated	Thicker mix; pre-soak fabric; add PVA glue to slurry
Lace pattern not showing in concrete	Slurry applied too thick	Thinner coat; brush into weave; press gently with fingers
Cracks in cured surface	Dried too fast; moved during cure	Mist every 2h; cover from sun/wind; do not touch for 48h
Fabric stuck to pot	Plastic wrap not used or tore	Always double-wrap the pot; twist gently to release
Dress shape looks lumpy	Folds not shaped before setting	Work faster; reshape within first 15 min; support with foil
Surface crumbles when touched	Not enough cement; too much water	Thicker slurry; apply 2–3 coats; cure fully before handling
Flowers dying in planter	No drainage; wrong soil	Always add drainage gravel; use quality potting mix

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